

| By Saurabh Shukla |

Far away from New Delhi, a sleepy monastery in Tawang in India's north-eastern state of Arunachal Pradesh has become the epicentre of geopolitical seismic shocks in Asia as the two big giants, India and China, locked horns over the week-long visit of the Dalai Lama. China considers Arunachal Pradesh a part of southern Tibet while India maintains that it is its integral part. So the visit by the Dalai Lama was also aimed at proving a point that India can withstand Chinese pressure.

While diplomatic statements are usually couched in niceties, the tenor was aggressive. "The Indian side allowed the Dalai Lama to visit the disputed eastern section of the Sino-India border, regardless of China's grave concerns and China is strongly dissatisfied with this," says Qin Gang spokesperson of the Chinese Foreign Office.

"We cannot tell the Dalai Lama to go or not to go to a certain place... but the Chinese shouldn't read into anything. We want cordial relations with China," External Affairs Minister S.M. Krishna told INDIA TODAY.

Diplomatic sources believe what has infuriated the Chinese is that India has ignored them. China had warned India of consequences when Chinese Foreign Minister Yang Jiechi met his Indian counterpart Krishna in Bangalore on the sidelines of a trilateral meeting on October 27. The Chinese were worried that the Dalai Lama's visit to Tawang would spark a reaction in Tibet. Last year, China faced its worst unrest in Tibet, and Beijing has since been on the backfoot on this issue.

In diplomacy, timing has a critical role to play. But why has India decided to take on China now? The decision to let the visit go forward was taken despite reservations within a section of the Indian establishment. South Block insiders say that when the matter was discussed by the prime minister and his national security team, including the key cabinet min-

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Proving a POINT

In standing firm on the Dalai Lama's Tawang visit, India shows a new resolve to take on an aggressive China

isters of finance, defence, external affairs and home, last month, the overwhelming view was that backing down in the face of an aggressive Chinese stand on the boundary dispute would send out a wrong message and would also embolden Beijing.

While the visit may not have been by design, it certainly was not accidental and was intended to send a message that India cannot be

bullied, especially when it concerns matters of sovereignty. India also wants to convey that the status of Arunachal Pradesh is non-negotiable.

Analysts believe that Beijing's assessment was that the Indian Government would buckle down under pressure, as even the pre-eminent global power, the US, clamped up under pressure when President Barack Obama didn't meet the Dalai Lama